BROKILD APPS · VST3 INSTRUMENT

BLADE RUINER

Three synthesisers, one city, and at least one of them always awake.

User Manual

Quick start · The three layers · Try this

Version 1.0

August 2026 · Windows VST3 · build 260822.6

01 What this is

An atmospheric synthesiser in three layers, each with its own engine and its own room. **LOS ANGELES** is the city: a drone that does not stop. **DECKARD** is the instrument you play over it. **REPLICANT** is the machine in the next room that has been counting all along.

They are not three presets of one synthesiser. They are three different synthesisers that share an output stage, and they can run in any combination — one, two, or all three at once. Each has its own page, and each page looks like the place it comes from.

The five things to know first

Something is always playing	The last live layer cannot be switched off. Press its lamp and the panel says *SOMETHING HAS TO BE PLAYING* and puts it back. This is deliberate: the instrument is an atmosphere, and an atmosphere that can be silenced by one click is a mixer channel.
LOS ANGELES does not need a keyboard	It is a drone. Load the plugin and it is already sounding. Switch its TRIGGER to **KEYED** if you would rather it waited for you.
DECKARD is the one you play	Eight voices, two oscillators and a sub each, a ladder filter with its own envelope, and the ensemble chorus that does most of the emotional work.
REPLICANT keeps its own time	A sixteen-step sequence locked to the host tempo, built from a six-bit seed. Same seed, same machine, always.
RANDOM is a mood organ	It dials a number and tells you what the number means. Section 07.

> **It is an instrument, not an effect.** Stereo out, MIDI in, no audio input. There is a two-octave keyboard along the bottom of the panel for when there is no MIDI keyboard in the room.

02 Quick start

FIVE MINUTES

1. **Load it and listen.**
   LOS ANGELES is already running. Nothing has to be played for the instrument to be doing something.

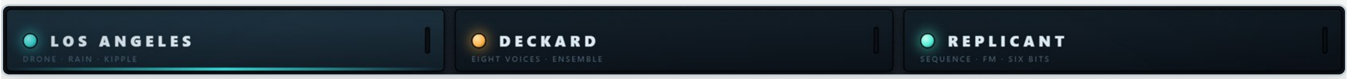
2. **Turn SMOG down and DRIFT up.**
   The city opens out and starts moving. These two controls do more for the atmosphere than anything else on the page.

3. **Play a slow chord.**
   That is DECKARD, over the top. Minor triads, held, low in the keyboard — this instrument is not in a hurry.

4. **Turn ENSEMBLE up.**
   Somewhere around 70 % it stops being a chorus and becomes the sound. Then lengthen RELEASE until the chords overlap.

5. **Light the REPLICANT lamp.**
   A sequence starts, in time with the host. Drag the **SEED** slider and it becomes a different machine at every step.

6. **Press RANDOM when you are stuck.**
   It re-rolls the character of all three layers and leaves the output, the tuning and the three layer levels exactly where they are.



> Click a name to open its page; click its lamp to switch the layer on or off. The bar on the right of each tab is that layer's own level, so you can see which one is making the noise you are hearing without opening its page.

> LIGHT, at the left of the header, is for rooms this panel was not designed for. It is a gamma curve rather than a brightness control: it lifts the shadows — where everything on a panel this dark lives — and steepens the contrast down there, while leaving the highlights where they are instead of flattening them into white. Double-click the slider to put it back to nothing. It is a view setting, remembered per machine, never saved into a patch.

03 The three layers

Everything below is per layer. The only things they share are the keyboard, the tuning, and the output.

The lamp	On or off. The tab dims when the layer is dark. The last one refuses to go out.
LEVEL	Each layer's own trim, printed in dB. Unity is at about 71 %. RANDOM never touches these, so a roll of the dice changes the character and not the balance.
MIDI	All three layers hear the same notes. DECKARD plays them. LOS ANGELES follows the lowest held note when its TRIGGER is KEYED. REPLICANT transposes its sequence from the lowest held note when its CLOCK is KEYED.
OUTPUT / TUNE	In the footer. TUNE is ±100 cents and moves all three layers together, including the sequence.
LIMITER	A smooth, musical gain reduction on the output. The lamp beside the meter lights when it is working.

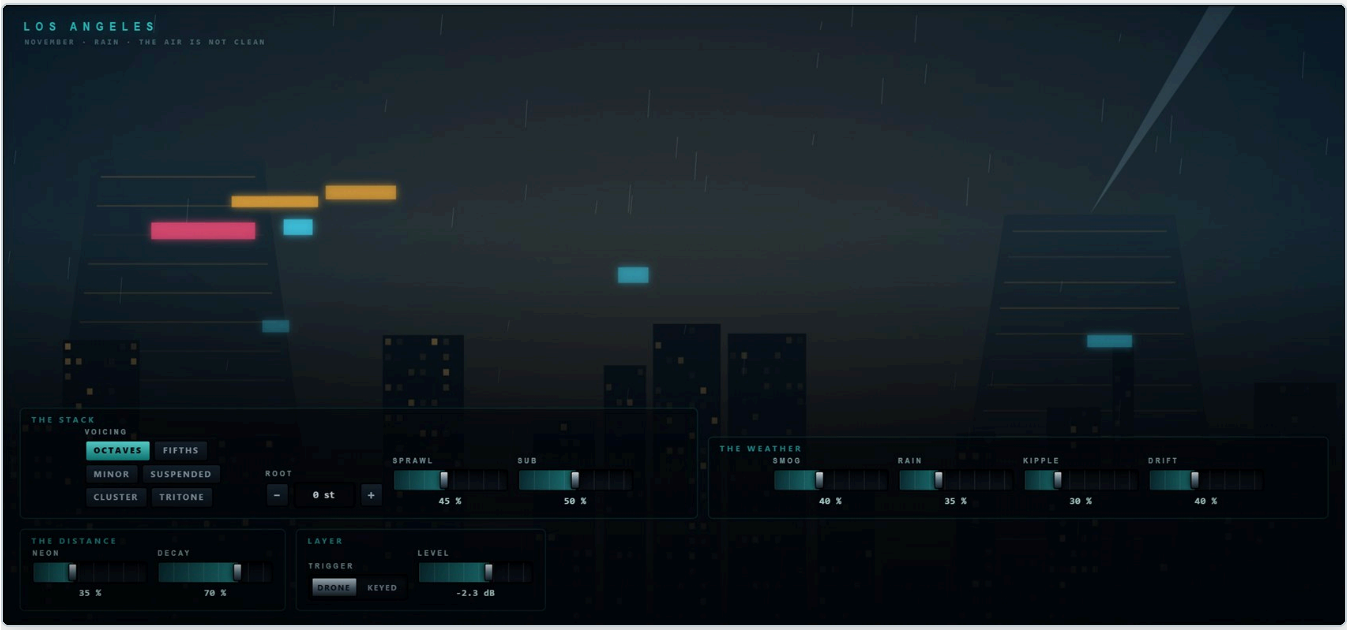
> **The limiter switch does not remove the ceiling.** It turns off the smooth gain reduction; a soft ceiling stays in place either way, because an instrument has no business emitting anything above full scale. It is transparent below about 70 % of full scale and asymptotic above it, so it only ever catches the first millisecond of a transient the limiter has not reached yet — measured at 1.75 before it was there.

Playing all three at once

The layers are summed, not mixed cleverly, and they occupy different places on purpose: the drone is wide and low, the polysynth sits in the middle, the sequence is narrow and bright and panned by step. If it gets crowded, the first thing to reach for is **SMOG** on LOS ANGELES — darkening the city is what makes room for everything else.

Los Angeles

Nine oscillators on one chord, a rain of filtered noise, grains of dust, and a reverb big enough to lose a city in. It is the only layer that plays itself.



The skyline is lit by the instrument: each building's windows brighten with the energy in that part of the spectrum, the rain thickens with the RAIN control, and the haze over the whole thing is SMOG. The searchlight sweeps whether or not anyone is watching.

The stack

VOICING	Which chord the nine oscillators are spread across. **OCTAVES** is bare and enormous. **FIFTHS** is open and old. **MINOR** and **SUSPENDED** are the two that sound like weather. **CLUSTER** is crowded. **TRITONE** is the one that makes the city feel wrong.
ROOT	±12 semitones from A. The drone is rooted low — a bass instrument that happens to fill the room.
SPRAWL	How far apart the nine are detuned, up to about a third of a semitone end to end. Small values beat slowly; large ones stop being a chord and become a place.
SUB	A sine an octave under the root. It goes to the speakers but never into the reverb, because a 40 Hz drone smeared over eight seconds is mud, not depth.

The weather

SMOG	How dark. This is a filter, and it is the master control of the whole layer: everything else is quieter and further away with the smog up.
RAIN	Filtered noise through three wandering resonances, panned apart. The rain on the picture is the same number.
KIPPLE	Entropy. It does two things at once: it drives the stack into an asymmetric saturation and a slowly-moving comb, and it starts throwing grains — short decaying resonances at random pitches, panned at random. Up at the top it is genuinely dirty.
DRIFT	How much everything moves. Each oscillator has its own drift running at its own speed, between forty seconds and two minutes a cycle, and the smog moves with them. Slow enough that you never catch it.

The distance

NEON	Shimmer. An octave-up copy of the reverb tail is folded back into its own input, so the top of the sound keeps climbing. A little is a glow; a lot is a chorus of ghosts.
DECAY	How long the reverb holds on. Near the top the tail is measured in tens of seconds and the layer stops having a beginning.
TRIGGER	**DRONE**: it plays, always. **KEYED**: it swells in when you hold a note and falls away over four seconds when you let go, following the lowest note you are holding.

> **KIPPLE** is Philip K. Dick's word, from *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* — the useless matter that accumulates in an empty building whether or not anybody adds to it. It seemed the right name for a control that only ever makes things dirtier.

05 Deckard

THE POLYSYNTH

Eight voices built the way the big Japanese polysynth of 1977 was built: two oscillators and a sub per voice, a four-pole ladder with its own envelope, a vibrato that arrives late, and an ensemble chorus doing more work than anything else in the signal path.

The envelope, thrown across the wall like a projection: attack, decay, sustain and release, drawn from the four knobs below it. The blinds and the lamp are the room; the eight lamps top right are the eight voices, lighting as you play.

Oscillator

SHAPE	**SAW** is the pad. **PULSE** has a slow width modulation shared by the whole keyboard, as the hardware did. **SAW+PULSE** is the two together, one per oscillator. **RING** replaces the second oscillator with a sine and multiplies — metallic, and much quieter, which is correct.
OCTAVE	±2 octaves.
DETUNE	The two oscillators apart, up to 16 cents each way. This is the thickness control.
RING	Mixes in the product of the two oscillators regardless of SHAPE. Small amounts add a hollow edge; large amounts remove the fundamental.

Filter and contour

BRILLIANCE	The cutoff, printed in Hz. It key-tracks, so a chord does not get duller as it goes up.
RESONANCE	Feedback around the four poles, through a saturator — which is what makes a ladder sound like a ladder rather than like four filters.
ENVELOPE	How much the contour opens the filter, scaled by how hard the note was played. This and BRILLIANCE together are the instrument.
ATTACK · DECAY · SUSTAIN · RELEASE	Amplitude, and a second slightly faster copy of the same shape driving the filter. Attack is linear so it can be instant; decay and release are exponential, because a pad whose tail falls off a cliff is a pad you can hear stopping.

The room

ENSEMBLE	Three modulated taps a third of a cycle apart. Below 40 % it is a widener; above 70 % it is the sound.
VIBRATO	Arrives late, over about a second of held note, and stops when you let go. It is not an effect on the note; it is something a player does to a note that is already sounding.
GLIDE	Portamento, up to 1.6 s. Prints OFF at zero.
SPACE	The layer's own reverb, smaller and warmer than the city's.

Replicant

A sixteen-step sequence driving a two-operator FM voice with an inharmonic ratio, a bit-crusher, and a heartbeat on the downbeat. It runs on the host's clock and it does not get tired.

> The row across the middle is the sequence: filled steps play, brighter ones are accented, and the outlined one is where the machine is now. The iris top right is a Voigt-Kampff readout — its pupil contracts on every note. The steps beyond the LENGTH you have set are dimmed rather than hidden, because the pattern is still there underneath.

Nexus-6

The **SEED** is a six-bit number, 0 to 63, and it is the whole pattern. Every seed produces a different arrangement of gates, pitches and accents, deterministically — the same seed is always the same machine, in this session, in this project, and on anybody else's computer. The six lamps under the slider are the number in binary, which is the only reason it is six bits and not eight.

SEED	0 – 63. Drag it and the machine rebuilds at every step. All 64 are audibly different; the bench checks that.
RATE	The step length, as a note division of the host tempo — from a half note down to a thirty-second, with two triplet settings.
LENGTH	4 to 16 steps. Shorter lengths turn a pattern into a loop you can recognise; 16 is long enough to stay unfamiliar.
CLOCK	**FREE**: it runs whenever the layer is live. **KEYED**: it runs only while a note is held, and transposes to the lowest one.

The voice

METAL	Walks the modulator up a ladder of ratios a bell has and a piano does not — 1, 2, √2, 3, π-ish, and on up to 7.07 — and increases the modulation depth as it goes. At the bottom it is a soft mallet; at the top there is no fundamental you could name.
DECAY	How long each step rings, 15 ms to 1.6 s. Long decays over a fast RATE is how the layer stops being a sequence and becomes a texture.
MENACE	Drive, filter resonance, and the sub heartbeat that lands on step one. This is the danger control.

The fault

GLITCH	Sample-and-hold plus bit reduction, and above about 45 % it starts occasionally stuttering — repeating the last quarter of a step. Which steps stutter is decided fresh each time, so it never becomes part of the pattern.
SPREAD	Alternate steps panned apart.
SPACE	A short, hard room. Not the city's.

07 Patches and the mood organ

SAVING, LOADING, DIALLING

SAVE and LOAD

A patch is a small JSON file holding all 46 values and nothing else — no audio, no window size, no machine-specific paths. **SAVE** opens a dialog; **LOAD** drops a menu of whatever is in your patch folder, with sub-folders as sub-menus.

The folder starts as `User presets` beside the installed `.vst3`, so a library travels with the plugin. If that folder cannot be written to, `Documents\Blade Ruiner Presets` is used instead. Saving somewhere else once makes that the new folder. The choice is remembered in your own settings rather than in the project, so it survives across hosts.

The mood organ

There is a dial in the header marked **MOOD**, and it goes from 0 to 999. Every one of those thousand numbers *is* a patch.

Dialling a number writes every character parameter in all three layers — which are live, the voicing, the weather, the oscillator, the seed, the shape of everything — and prints the line of text that belongs to that number. **RANDOM** simply dials a number at random. The levels, the tuning and the limiter are never touched, so a mood changes what the machine is thinking about and not how loud it is.

> **Every mood makes a sound on its own.** Not just “one layer live” — DECKARD needs keys, and so does a keyed LOS ANGELES or a keyed REPLICANT, so a perfectly legal combination could leave the dial silent until you played a note. 134 of the thousand did, including 42. If nothing would be free-running, the city comes on and stays on.

> **The same number is always the same instrument.** Nothing about a mood depends on the clock, the session, or which machine it is running on: the seed drives the generator and nothing else does. 481 today is 481 next year and 481 on somebody else's computer, which is the only thing that makes a three-digit number worth writing down.

> **The dial reads — until you turn it.** The patch the plugin ships with is hand-made and is not one of the thousand, and printing a number over a patch that number did not produce is a small lie — it shows the moment you dial away and come back. Loading a patch from disk brings its mood back with it.

Drag the number, roll the wheel over it, or step it with the two buttons. Shift moves ten at a time, which matters when there are a thousand of them.

The thousand lines

Nineteen of the descriptions are written by hand. **Five of those are Philip K. Dick's own**, near enough, from *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*:

CODE	WHAT YOU HAVE DIALLED
3	a stimulus to dial, for when you cannot face dialling
382	six hours of self-accusatory depression
481	awareness of the manifold possibilities open to me in the future
594	pleased acknowledgment of a spouse's superior wisdom in all matters
888	the desire to watch television, no matter what is on it

Two are not Dick at all. **451** and **42** belong to other books by other authors, and it would be a poor sort of dystopia that did not nod to its neighbours — *the wish to remember a book by heart, in case*, and *the calm of having the answer, and no longer the question*. Neither of them winks. They are written as moods, and if you do not already know the two numbers you will read straight past them.

Twelve more are ours, written in the same voice — 127, *placid recognition of one's own obsolescence*; 741, *the wish to be looked at by something that can see*; 964, *the calm of a room where the television has just been turned off*. The dial marks the written ones as you pass them.

The other 981 are generated from the seed by a small grammar — nine sentence shapes, each with its own vocabulary chosen so that every combination inside it is a sentence somebody might actually write. Which is why there are nine small tables rather than one big one: a shared noun list would eventually produce *gratitude for one's own obsolescence*, and half of it would read as nonsense.

0	a clear view of the distance to the nearest real thing
17	willingness to begin again on a Tuesday
250	a long memory of a name one has stopped using
613	a small, clean sense of weather that is not dust
999	a flicker of resentment at weather arriving on schedule

> **No two of the thousand share a line.** Drawing the words at random gave 664 distinct descriptions out of 1000 — a third of the dial repeating itself — so the mapping is injective by construction instead: the seed is permuted, split between the sentence shapes by a fixed allocation, and each shape walks its own combinations by a stride coprime with its size. The bench checks all thousand, both ways, on every build.

Automation

All 46 sound parameters are host-automatable and print properly in an automation lane — *MINOR*, *1/8T*, *N-06*, *954 Hz*, *810 ms* — rather than as bare numbers. **MOOD is deliberately not automatable**: it rewrites forty other parameters, and a lane that fights forty other lanes is a lane nobody can use. It is saved in the patch and in the project like everything else. The three layer switches are among them, so a host can turn a layer on and off in time. If a host manages to switch all three off at once, the plugin keeps the last one sounding and puts the parameter back.

Try this

The opening shot

LOS ANGELES alone. **VOICING** FIFTHS, **SPRAWL** 70 %, **SMOG** 25 %, **RAIN** 55 %, **NEON** 60 %, **DECAY** 90 %, **DRIFT** 70 %, **KIPPLE** 15 %.

Enormous, slow, and it never quite repeats. Leave it running while you do something else and it will still be interesting when you come back.

Something in the building

REPLICANT alone. **RATE** 1/16, **LENGTH** 12, **METAL** 70 %, **DECAY** 20 %, **MENACE** 65 %, **GLITCH** 55 %, **SPREAD** 90 %. Then walk the **SEED**.

Mechanical, wrong, and it will not stop. Drop the layer level and put it under the other two rather than in front of them.

Held brass

DECKARD. **SHAPE** SAW, **DETUNE** 45 %, **BRILLIANCE** 25 %, **ENVELOPE** 80 %, **RESONANCE** 30 %, **ATTACK** 35 %, **RELEASE** 70 %, **ENSEMBLE** 85 %, **SPACE** 70 %.

The chord that opens slowly and then keeps opening. Play it low and in fourths.

The whole film

All three live. LOS ANGELES **TRITONE** at 40 % level; DECKARD with a long **RELEASE** and **ENSEMBLE** at 90 %; REPLICANT at **1/8T**, low level, **SPACE** 60 %.

Play two chords, four bars apart, and let the rest of it happen.

The dust

LOS ANGELES. **KIPPLE** 85 %, **SMOG** 70 %, **SUB** 20 %, **VOICING** CLUSTER, **SPRAWL** 30 %.

A room that has not been opened in years. Almost no pitch left, and a great deal of grit.

Keyed city

LOS ANGELES **TRIGGER** to KEYED, **DECAY** 95 %, DECKARD off, REPLICANT off. Hold one note. Let go. Hold another.

The city as an instrument: enormous swells that take four seconds to arrive and eight to leave.

09 Installing & specifications

Installing

1. **Unzip.**
   Copy `Blade Ruiner.vst3` — the whole folder — into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\`. A sub-folder such as `...\VST3\Brokild\` is fine; hosts look inside.

2. **Rescan.**
   Start your DAW and let it rescan plugins. It appears as an **instrument**, manufacturer Brokild.

3. **Or just run it.**
   `Blade Ruiner.exe` in the same zip is the standalone version; it picks its audio and MIDI devices from its own options menu.

> **If the panel does not appear** — the interface is drawn in a WebView2 surface, which every up-to-date Windows 10 and 11 already has. If yours does not, install the free Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime and reopen the plugin. The audio keeps working with the window shut either way.

> **If Windows refuses to load it at all** and reports "*An Application Control policy has blocked this file*", that is **Smart App Control**. It decides *per file*, from a cloud reputation lookup, and it can return a block for one unsigned binary while happily loading another — build 260822.1 of this plugin was blocked on the machine it was written on, while three other unsigned plugins in the same folder loaded, and a rebuild of the identical program cleared it. So the block attaches to that exact copy of the file rather than to the plugin: a later build may well load where an earlier one did not. Failing that, Windows Security → App & browser control → Smart App Control lets you turn it off — note that switching it off is not reversible without reinstalling Windows. Most machines do not have it enabled at all.

Specifications

Format	VST3 instrument, 64-bit Windows. Standalone included.
Bus	Stereo out. MIDI in. No audio input.
Layers	Three independent engines, any combination, at least one always live.
Polyphony	Deckard: 8 voices with oldest-note stealing. Los Angeles: 9 oscillators plus a sub, always. Replicant: monophonic by design.
Parameters	47. The 46 sound parameters are host-automatable; MOOD is state.
Sample rates	Any. Tested at 44.1, 48, 88.2 and 96 kHz — the drone lands on the same frequency at all four.
Tempo	Replicant follows the host. With no host tempo it runs at 120.
Latency	None reported, and none introduced.
CPU	Rises with the number of live layers and with Deckard's polyphony. The city is the cheapest of the three; the reverbs are the expensive part.
Network	None. It does not open a socket, and there is nothing to allow through a firewall.

What was measured

The engine has an offline bench that renders real audio and looks at it: every control at both extremes, 300 random machines with all three layers live, all 64 seeds (bounded, audible, and no two alike), four sample rates, a sixty-second run at maximum shimmer and kipple to prove nothing creeps upward, and a Goertzel check that the A1 drone really is at 55 Hz and that the tuning control really moves it. It also dials all thousand moods twice over and proves that each gives the same patch and the same line both times, that every value lands inside its own range, and that no two of the thousand collide. A separate check reads the source and proves that the parameter tables, the automation order and the panel all name the same 46 things in the same order.

Blade Ruiner — Brokild Apps. Build 260822.6, August 2026.
Native C++ audio, JUCE 8, interface drawn in the plugin's own window.
With acknowledgements to Philip K. Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), from which the kipple, the mood organ, the Voigt-Kampff scale and the Rosen Association are borrowed.
Free to use. No installer, no account, no telemetry, nothing phones home.